Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra Strategic Plan

2026-2027

Approved by the SCO Board September 17, 2026

Executive Summary

The Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra is designed to educate and inspire string students through group classes and ensembles in Port Angeles and Sequim. The primary location focus is Sequim as it does not have its own string program in the Sequim school district, but the Sequim Community Orchestra board has discovered over the last 12 years that Sequim is best supported by working together with the vibrant community of educators, administrators, donors, and string organizations from across the Olympic Peninsula, and also by bringing together students from across the peninsula into ensembles whenever possible.

The Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra currently operates a rolling 2 year master plan describing its class matriculation structure and budget plan to produce a neutral budget throughout its growth plan which began in June 2025. The 2026-2027 course list currently reflects what we currently expect to be steady state for the PCYO, with 1-3 Sprouts groups for very young students per town (dependent on enrollment), 1-3 adult strings groups (dependent on enrollment) and 3 graduated 6+ ensembles per town, meeting in 3 8-week terms, covering classes between September and May, with a special optional condensed Holiday term in November and early December.

Sequim Community Orchestra, a 501(c)(3) non-profit, funds and administers the program through a combination of tuition, donations, and grants when available. Although the program, initially known as SCO String Kids, was funded primarily by grants for years, that has not been a viable method since the pandemic, and the program currently operates funded roughly 75% through tuition, with the remaining made up by smaller individual donations.

The Sequim Community Orchestra does not consider it to be consistent with its core values to deny any student the ability to learn music for financial reasons, and so the program offers

generous scholarships to all families and is constantly reworking its offerings and budget to meet the needs of families while providing the best educational opportunities available. With improved funding, we are able to offer more and better educational services at less cost to parents. With less funding we are forced to flexibly reduce our offerings while still aiming for our educational goals.

Organizational Overview & History

The Sequim Community Orchestra and the youth educational program previously known as "SCO String Kids" were founded in 2012 together as synergistic programs. The SCO was to serve intermediate-level student and adult string, wind, and percussion players in the community, while the SCO String Kids was envisioned to be a drop-in replacement for a strings program for the Sequim School District. It was designed to build up one grade at a time into a complete program, with instruments coming from donations from the community, and the Sequim Community Orchestra managing hiring and other matters for the school district until such time it chose to take the program in. For various reasons (including but not limited to a new superintendent, tightened budgets, and a failed levy), the Sequim school district elected not to take in the program, but the program still continues to exist and support string students.

In June 2025, the Sequim Community Orchestra board reviewed the program from the ground up. The program had a teacher and 8 second and third year students, and the students were happy and learning their instruments and wished to continue. Budgetarily though, the program was not doing well because the administration of the program was not rigorous enough to handle the transition from being a fully grant-funded program to a program that was part tuition and part donation funded, with few if any grants. This required significant changes to the administrative and budgetary structure of the program as well as a plan to ensure the program could survive if the people involved in the restructuring were no longer present.

The changes were driven by the leaders and membership of the SCO, who came from across the Olympic Peninsula, from as far as Joyce to the west and as far as Quilcene to the south east. The narrow focus of the SCO String Kids on only Sequim students seemed inappropriate given the broad geographical reach of the membership and board of the Orchestra. It was thought that this broad reach could be leveraged to grow the program beyond Sequim and provide

significant economies of scale to address the program's increased administrative and budgetary needs after the transition from being grant-funded.

Another driver of the restructuring was the loss of the North Olympic Youth Symphony in 2006 in Port Angeles. This loss was felt more and more poignantly as many members of NOYS have returned to the peninsula over the last ten years and realized that nearly an entire generation has passed wherein Sequim and Port Angeles students (and Joyce and Chimacum) have not experienced the benefits of participating in a youth orchestra.

Given all these factors, the board elected to rename the SCO Strings Kid to the Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra in June 2025 and begin the process of building a youth orchestra program (and not simply a school orchestra replacement program) in both Port Angeles and Sequim.

In Fall 2025, we added a beginners class to the Port Angeles side of the Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra.

In Fall 2026, to complete our two year graduated ensemble plan from June, we added both an intermediate group (which the beginners graduated into) as well as an advanced Youth Orchestra ensemble for students with at least 3 years of study. These three classes, Beginner, Intermediate, and Youth Orchestra, form the core program of the Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra that we fundraise for, and that currently run in both Port Angeles and Sequim. Other classes such as Sprouts and Adult Strings are constructed and contracted to be as revenue neutral as possible, and just act as supportive programs for students who need them, but their presence or absence is not critical to the core program which provides the first 5-6 years of string education in Sequim or Port Angeles, with students generally graduating into the Sequim Community Orchestra, which acts at a high school level.

Mission, Vision, and Core Values

Mission Statement

The mission statement of the PCYO is the same as that of the SCO:

The mission of the Sequim Community Orchestra is threefold:

1. Education in orchestral music and performance for musicians of all ages.
2. Entertaining and informing our community through orchestral performances.
3. Supporting strings education for students of the community.

Vision Statement

The mission of the PCYO is a reduced version of that of the SCO:
The Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra aims to provide beginner and intermediate student musicians of the Peninsula with educational and inspirational group environments that will help players grow artistically and technically so they are better enabled to experience the many benefits of playing orchestral music with their musical communities.

Core Values

The core values of the PCYO are that of the SCO:

- Playing music together makes us better.
- Orchestral music is for everyone.
- Mistakes and continual improvement are a necessary part of success.

Situational Analysis

Strengths

The SCO & Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra has significantly strengthened its administrative framework over the last 15 months.

1. First, in July 2025, the board agreed on a concrete matriculation plan and budget for 2025-2026 and 2026-2027, followed it carefully (implementing only revenue neutral alterations), and came out positive in its budget due to healthy community donations.
    a. **Note**: This matriculation and enrollment plan diverged from that of the standard school orchestra program that was originally envisioned by the SCO in 2012, as the original design was for one year of class per level. The combination of years 2 and 3 into an intermediate class, and years 4-6 into the youth orchestra make

this a much more realizable matriculation budget than the original plan of one class per year. We also finalized years 7-9 as "graduation" into the SCO, with any subsequent year students being encouraged to further audition and graduate into the Port Angeles Symphony Orchestra.

2. Second, the board agreed on and implemented a registration platform, Jovial, to manage students in the program and ensure during the new growth, that enrollment, tuition billing, and reconciliation was as painless as possible for program administration.
3. Third, the board agreed on and adopted a budget platform, Money Minder, to ensure that as the program grew, the budget could be carefully tracked while not adding overly to the administrative duties of the treasurer.
4. Fourth, the board agreed on and formed a special committee, headed by the board president and staffed by parents, to manage the strategic direction of the children's program, and designated a committee member to orchestrate fundraising activities for the program.
5. Fifth, the board has brought on a special advisor to the president and PCYO committee to ensure the educational and artistic direction of the children's program is coherent and consistent.

The SCO Board and committee has also worked to better integrate its children's program with the musical community on the Olympic Peninsula, with regular discussions, feedback, and cooperation with Olympic Strings, the Port Angeles Symphony Orchestra, Port Angeles School District orchestra instructors, and Music on the Strait.

The SCO Board and committee has built a toolbox of contacts and activities to ensure that potential orchestra students around Clallam County who may benefit from our program are aware of it, including online with a website, Facebook, and offline with newspapers, flyers, library demos, school discussions, and radio spots discussing our program.

At the end of the 2026 SCO year, we had several new members join our board and a few move around to find positions that better fit their skills. The SCO board currently has a President, Vice-President, Treasurer, Secretary, 3 directors at large (one who assists the treasurer), and 3 parent members on the PCYO committee, one of whom is the designated fundraising coordinator.

We currently have 4 contracted PCYO directors who direct the ensembles, one of whom is also the advisor to the board on educational and artistic matters.

Weaknesses

With the growth of our program from 8 students at the end of Spring 2025 to 79 at the beginning of Fall 2026, adequate volunteer administration and coordination between that administration is a major focus. While we continue working to find the best time, tools, people, and platforms, the children's program administration is all volunteer. The position of executive director for the children's program is both critical and time-consuming. For now the SCO board president serves in this role as committee head, and plans to step exclusively into the PCYO director position officially once a suitable candidate for board president is found. Alternatively, the PCYO director position could be broken up more if suitable candidates can be found to take on smaller pieces of the duty.

Our program currently relies on only 25% in community donations. This could be considered a weakness, but historical budget information shows this is manageable. This limited 25% reliance is only achievable because of program compromises (such as reduced class term length) and careful attention to enrollment parameters and the necessary outreach to support those parameters, which create the tuition base for the program.

Our offering of scholarships to all students without reservation creates a difficult-to-plan-for weakness. We navigate this as carefully as we can by gently discussing with each family the value of spreading our scholarships around and offering partial scholarships whenever that meets family needs.

Opportunities

While we are ecstatic to have 79 students in our program at the beginning of Fall 2026, the youth orchestra in both Port Angeles and Sequim is essentially nascent. We expect the youth orchestra ensembles to grow in both towns from their current enrollment of 8-9 students each to 24+ students, as students matriculate upwards into the youth orchestra in both Sequim and Port Angeles, and as students and families in the Port Angeles school district relearn the value of a local youth orchestra.

The Sprouts program is also still nascent. Opportunities for growth are currently limited by only having 1 instructor with limited hours available. If more of our local teachers could obtain the skills needed to teach students aged 3-6, this program would be more accessible to more students. We may seek funding for opportunities for our interested directors to obtain these specialized skills to work with very young children in the future.

The intermediate class in both Port Angeles and Sequim is currently populated by only 1 year of beginner students, but we do plan for this to be a two year class and so double in size.

Thus, while our course offerings are not expected to change significantly in the next few years, we anticipate an average program enrollment of 100-125 once the program has been running long enough to fully populate all levels of the program, assuming we can continue to start beginner classes of the sizes we have the last 2 years and we suffer no more than standard attrition rates.

Threats

Ongoing economic turmoil does create reduced ability to enroll in our classes without a scholarship. Unless the economic situation of the peninsula changes drastically though in the next 5 years, we don't anticipate this to be a major creator of new problems. If it does, we will flexibly adjust to provide the best educational experience we can given whatever economic situation we find ourselves in.

The beginner program is critical to Sequim, and reduced enrollment in that class in any given year can cause dire consequences for the sustainability of the program in future years in Sequim as it has no school program from which to recruit additional intermediate students. We hope that multiple levels of the program in both Port Angeles and Sequim, with an anticipated bigger Youth Orchestra ensemble, will balance that risk.

In Port Angeles, where there is a strings program in the public schools, the program model will likely be different than the model used in Sequim. The goal is to welcome younger students as well as private and home school students. For that reason, we intend to be flexible with the construction of the Port Angeles ensembles to meet the needs of students in a different educational environment with significantly more strings support.

Stakeholder Insight

The board and artistic directors regularly meet and discuss with community members who are affected by our program and who can benefit from it. During the summer of 2025, the board president conducted 9 in person meetings from the orchestral community to discuss the potential fit of the Peninsula Community Youth Orchestra with existing programs. Since then, we've continued discussing regularly and accepting feedback from community members to ensure our program fits in well with others on the peninsula.

The SCO Board has conducted surveys at the end of each term and prior to program start, and with each major change, to gather information from existing and potential students on how the program fits family needs, from program instruction, length, pricing, as well as the programs' ensemble offerings. The SCO Board also conducts a PCYO General Meeting lead by the PCYO committee at least once annually to hear from interested parties and families in person.

Market Landscape & Competitor Review

In Sequim, we remain the only group strings program for students. There are also few private teachers in Sequim, and no other established group strings programs at this time. (There were some in the last 12 years, but they have dissolved or stopped including strings in their programs.)

In Port Angeles, the school district remains the primary place for group strings. It offers classes for students who wish to play a string instrument in fourth grade and above. The Port Angeles school district has a decades-long award-winning orchestral program and many private teachers. Prior to our program, there was no group instruction for strings below fourth grade.

There does exist in Port Angeles a homeschool group, Olympic Peninsula Home Connections, which offers a beginner violin class. In our latest discussion with the teacher, she told us that she recommends her graduated or more intermediate students to our programs.

For students 3-6, there are no other group string classes, and there are no private lessons teachers except our Sprouts director who wish to accept students this age as it requires

specialized lesson plans which are very different from those for older children. There are also no group string classes for adults who are learning at the beginner level except ours.

In Port Angeles, there currently exists a single *before-school* strings program, Stringendo. Limited information is currently available about this program, but as far as we can discern, it is only available to enrolled public school students in middle school. This program is provided for free by Nathan Rodahl.

The PCYO considers its Youth Orchestra ensembles to be lower in general skill levels than the SCO. The SCO considers itself to be roughly at a high school level, and below that of the Port Angeles Symphony Orchestra (PASO). We hope to graduate PCYO students into the SCO and then into PASO.

Olympic Strings offers a few events in late August before our classes start. One of these events (Chamber Music Camp, at Lake Crescent) will accept students roughly the skill level we expect our youth orchestra students to be at the end of the 2026-2027 year and we plan to recommend our students to it. The other event, Sight Reading Workshop, accepts students of any age who can read music. This summer, we recommended it to our students and the majority of our intermediate students attended. Our current course plan does not have any regular programming in the summer, and if it offers any programming in the summer in the future, it would be in June or July so as not to compete with the already excellent Olympic Strings events.

Strategic Priorities or Pillars

Programmatic Impact & Growth

Our program has completed the majority of its growth at this point and is looking to solidify its place offering the ensembles it has. The two primary mechanisms solidifying the intermediate and youth orchestra ensembles are time and program acceptance. As students matriculate upwards from our beginner programs, they naturally fill the intermediate and youth orchestra ensembles. As string students in Port Angeles school district, Olympic Peninsula Home Connections, Joyce, Quilcene, and elsewhere hear about our programs, they may also decide to join and further fill it out.

We would like to have a solid matriculation plan (for example, once yearly or once every 2 years) for when new adult beginners may join and how they matriculate upwards into the SCO.

We are operating flexibly with respect to our Sprouts program for now, but ideally we would like all our children 7 and under to be in a Sprouts-like program instead of our regular beginner classes. Sprouts programs teach by rote instead of introducing note-reading, and are focused much more heavily on technique and child-friendly movement to keep the classes accessible to our youngest learners who may struggle in a seated learning situation.

Financial Sustainability & Revenue Diversification

Our fundraising coordinator has designed a collection of fundraisers our students may engage in throughout the year, including our regular bake sales, but also including new items including restaurant takeovers and specialized musical fundraisers. We use these funds to cover scholarships, instrument maintenance, and other one-offs that tuition doesn't quite cover. We also explicitly raise funds for certain instrument purchases as needed. (For example in 2025-2026, we fundraised $2,700 for cello purchases to expand our instrument library to allow students in both locations to borrow cellos.)

Our earned tuition income we manage carefully by ensuring classes meet their budgeted minimum.

We do not plan to rely on grants as part of our annual funding, but instead to improve our educational outcomes whenever possible on an annual basis, to improve program efficiency, and to meet new annual program needs such as increased instrument library diversity.

Capacity Building & Operations

- **IT:** The SCO Board president, Case Schmidt, who is a software developer, and the previous SCO Music Director, Phil Morgan-Ellis, who was a computer science teacher, use their information technology skills to manage the two websites, https://pcyo.kids and https://sequimcommunityorchestra.org respectively. These two also work with board members and directors to evaluate and incorporate necessary technology.

- **Staff:** The children's program currently staffs 4 contractor directors which, along with the volunteers involved in the program, collectively offer significant redundancy for substitutions and alterations if needed.
- **Venues:** The children's program currently utilizes Swisher Hall, Trinity United Methodist Church in Sequim, First United Methodist Church in Port Angeles, and St. Andrew's Episcopal Church in Port Angeles for classes. Arrangements with these venues are made by the board president. **Note:** The PCYO seeks on a long-term basis to form a stronger partnership arrangement with a venue in PA and/or Sequim that gives us greater flexibility to offer small classes, work with breakout groups from our ensembles, store instruments and music and materials, and potentially allow private instruction if such an arrangement could be made. (Not all of these needs need to be met by one venue.)
- **Storage:** We utilize a storage unit in Sequim for storage of our instrument library.

Community Engagement & Marketing

- **Brand awareness:** The Peninsula Community Orchestra has built a consistent brand with logos, font usage, colors, and website design. This brand is now recognizable to most of the existing musical community.
- **Advocacy:** The SCO Board President, SCO Music Director, PCYO Directors, and board at large advocate for the program at many local events, including Sequim & Port Angeles Back to School Fairs, the Clallam County Fair, the Sequim Irrigation Festival, the Holiday Market at Verne Burton, and the School Choice Fair.
- **Strategic Partnerships:** As discussed above, the PCYO collaborates regularly with Port Angeles Symphony Orchestra, Music on the Strait, Olympic Strings, and the Port Angeles school district.

Implementation Strategy & Action Plan

Goals

1. Provide a group strings program for as many students as the budget allows in Port Angeles and Sequim, acting as a complete program in Sequim and as a more supportive program in Port Angeles.

2. Maintain budget neutral enrollment of the 6+ ensembles as specified in the master course matriculation plan. Single courses may go below their enrollment between terms so long as the overall program is on target and other financial goals are met.
3. Maintain other programs (Sprouts and Adult Strings) so long as they can be offered in a budget neutral manner, so that very young students and adult string learners can have the same benefits age 6-12 children have in learning an instrument in a group.
4. Maintain tight integration and strong relationships with other string programs in the community.
5. Rely on directors for their expertise with teaching, and ensure they are aligned with the program strategy.

Tactics

1. Host regular concerts for the PCYO showing off student growth
2. Attend a collection of fairs as outreach to meet in person a collection of potential new students each year and show them the excitement of playing a string instrument
3. Utilize a toolbox of online and offline marketing tactics, mentioned above.

Accountability Matrix

Stay on Budget: Treasurer
Maintain Master Course Matriculation Plan: SCO Board President and SCO Music Director and PCYO Directors
Tight Integration with Local String Programs: SCO Music Director and SCO Board President
Host Concerts: PCYO Directors, with logistics from SCO Board President and artistic support from SCO Music Director
Attend Collection of Fairs: PCYO Committee Members, SCO Music Director, PCYO Directors
Marketing Tactics: SCO board President

Financial Plan & Resource Requirements

No *new* initiatives are planned in 2026-2027. Existing initiatives are discussed above and covered in exhaustive detail in the Master Course Matriculation Plan.

If we receive grants, we will perform the functions and changes described in the grant applications plans.

Human Resource Needs:

- We could use another Sprouts teacher to fill out the after-school availability for students 3-6.
- We are awaiting a new candidate for SCO Board President, so the current board president may take on exclusively the role of PCYO Executive Director.

Monitoring, Evaluation, & Learning Framework

- **Budget:** Budget adherence is tracked in MoneyMinder. The program goal is to be revenue neutral, or, more preferably, positive (via donations) so that we can build a longer runway.
- **Enrollment:** Enrollment adherence is tracked in Jovial. Enrollment goals are set in our Master Course Matriculation Plan to ensure we do not net a loss on the overall program, endangering its sustainability.
- **Contingency Planning:** Enrollment goals are set such that every program except beginners *may* be cancelled prior to starting for the term if the overall program cannot meet its financial goals. Instructor expenses for our classes are 85% of total costs on an average year. The contingency then, is to contract program expenses and release the students to individual instruction. Beginners cannot be cancelled as it endangers the future sustainability of the program to not run a beginner class.